OBITUARY

ASHA BHOSLE |1933-2026|

Voice of the Multiverse

Asha Bhosle's ghazals stirred an eternal autumn of yearning; her nightclub/ cabaret songs ignited an aural euphoria like no other

By Lalitha Suhasini



PTI

The biggest and only thrill as I watched *Dhurandhar* last year was when I heard Asha Bhosle sing the line '*pyaase, pyaase in mere labon ke liye*'. Her vocals tore through the streets on screen as a bike chase ensues and Yalina (Sara Arjun) clings to Hamza (Ranveer Singh). The image of Helen writhing across the dance floor in a scarlet sequined outfit was not the first one that came to my mind, even though the actor was the centrepiece of this cabaret hit from *Caravan* (1971) composed by R.D. Burman. And I doubt that my visual narrative will ever include Ranveer and Sara, riding the Triumph Bonneville T120 Black, when I hear 'Piya tu ab toh aaja'. When did Bhosle's aural stardom outshadow the visual aspects of a film?

Every time I've listened to an Asha Bhosle hit, I would picture the singer draped in a pastel-hued cotton silk Paithani, with yellow magnolia pinned neatly to the side of her bun and a strand of pearls wrapped around her neck. This is also the enduring memory from my first meeting with Bhosle ahead of her 70th birthday. She

Just as she dominated the '70s with R.D. Burman's nightclub hits, she owned the '50s and '60s with O.P. Nayyar's melodies. Composers like A.R. Rahman sought out Bhosle for the frantic breathwork she made famous in her cabaret songs